Call Prep: Russell Frees - Henricksen (Connect Call)

4:30-5:00 PM CDT (30 min) | Microsoft Teams (link on invite) | Refresh - prior prep sheets exist (2026-07-21, 2026-08-24), but the August intro invites were canceled and no conversation is on record

Calibration note: This is a peer/relationship introduction via mutual contact Rex Miller (July 2026), not a sales-sourced lead. Russell framed it from the start as wanting to learn how Improving's clients are navigating AI in his industry. Treat as a two-way exchange between peers. Do not pitch a specific Improving service today.

Who They Are

Company	Henricksen
Industry	Contract furniture dealership / commercial workplace solutions
HQ	Oak Brook, Illinois (new HQ/showroom at 1301 W. 22nd Street, Floor 11 - unveiled October 6, 2026)
Founded	Not found
Size	13 offices nationwide; represents 400+ manufacturers
Email domain	henricksen.com

Company Overview

Brief refresh - full background in the 2026-08-24 prep sheet. What is new since August: Henricksen unveiled its new Oak Brook HQ on October 6, 2026, designed around "evolving identity and flexible work styles" (a live showroom for the hybrid-workplace story they sell). Leadership moves continue: Brenda Lemmer joined as Senior Business Development Manager, A+D, Twin Cities (Oct 19), and Mark Dalton returned as Principal Emeritus and Regional Manager supporting the Peoria team (Sept 14). The growth-and-consolidation trajectory (Synergy acquisition, COFCO rebrand, vertical build-out in healthcare and architectural products) is unchanged - they are still the consolidator, and the challenge Russell speaks to publicly remains scaling consistent service across 13 offices.

Sources: henricksen.com newsroom (Oct 26, 2026 check) + prior prep sheet (2026-08-24). No CRM history or Improving engagement found for Henricksen.

Who He Is

- **Title:** President and CEO, Henricksen (confirmed via email signature and henricksen.com)
- **Education:** Miami University
- **Location:** Illinois (Oak Brook HQ base)

- **Public-facing work:** Active on LinkedIn; quoted directly in Henricksen's leadership-promotion press releases - hands-on, visible communicator about company direction
- **LinkedIn:** https://www.linkedin.com/in/russellfrees/

"Read on him": Strategy-focused CEO actively driving growth and consolidation - not a technology buyer. Calibrate as a peer exploring how other leaders are thinking about AI, not a prospect for a specific Improving service.

Common Connections

LinkedIn mutual connections not re-pulled this run (time-boxed refresh). Prior check (2026-08-24 prep) found a 500+ connection profile with second-degree mutuals present but could not extract specific names.

Reason for the Call

Russell Frees (President + CEO, Henricksen) was introduced to David by Rex Miller (rex@gomindshift.com) via email July 3, 2026, subject "Connecting you with David O'Hara" - "one of the more thoughtful leaders I know on putting AI to work the right way... I think you two should connect." Russell replied July 9, 2026, wanting to "connect more and learn about how you are seeing your clients navigate the AI in their space... certainly been pushing into our space." The August intro call was scheduled twice and canceled twice (Aug 24, 2026 cancellations on record), and no transcript or follow-up email exists in the vault. David sent this "Connect: David & Russell (Improving / Henricksen)" invite October 12, 2026 - a fresh attempt to land the conversation.

Do not assume:

- This is not a sales opportunity or pipeline activity - no CRM or sales touch found in email; this is a peer/relationship referral.
- Do not assume urgency or a defined business problem - Russell is exploring and learning, not responding to a crisis.
- Do not assume a first conversation already happened - the August invites were canceled and no record of a live call exists; treat this as the first real touchpoint unless he references one.
- Do not pitch a specific Improving service in the opening.

Suggested Talking Points / Questions

1. **Acknowledge the scheduling journey lightly:** the August attempts never landed - a quick "glad we finally got this on the calendar" resets it without dwelling.
2. **AI adoption reality in his space:** what is he seeing in contract furniture and workplace solutions around AI - what's working, what's not, where do his clients lean in or push back? (His own stated reason for the call.)
3. **The new HQ as an AI conversation opener:** Henricksen just unveiled a flagship HQ built around flexible work styles (Oct 6) - how workplace is being rethought is literally his product. How does AI change what his clients ask for in their spaces?

4. **Growth and consolidation as context:** 13 offices, acquisitions, vertical expansion (healthcare, architectural products) - how does AI factor into scaling service consistency across that footprint, a challenge he speaks to publicly?
5. **Reciprocal learning:** share a pattern or two from Improving's clients on AI adoption (activation over replacement, what actually gets past pilot) and ask what would be most useful to hear given where Henricksen is.

Landmines / Notes

- Don't pitch. Russell is deciding whether this is worth an ongoing relationship, not sitting through a discovery call.
- Don't lead with Improving's services - he's curious how you think, not what you sell.
- Don't assume Henricksen needs software or consulting - let him signal where value might exist.
- Don't reference the August cancellations as his fault (or yours) - keep it light and forward-looking.
- Don't dominate the air time - this should be a two-way exchange.

Open Questions Going In

- Whether any live conversation actually happened between July and now is unconfirmed - two August invites were canceled and no transcript or follow-up email exists. If he references a prior conversation, roll with it.
- Why now - David sent this invite Oct 12 with no new email context; unclear if something prompted the re-attempt.
- No stated agenda beyond "Connect" - Russell may pivot to a specific topic or keep it broad.
- One-off conversation or the start of an ongoing relationship - notice whether he signals interest in follow-up.